

Ancient Rome

The Roman Empire was one of the greatest empires the world has ever known. At its peak, Rome's armies were almost unchallenged, and its emperors ruled a huge area – from Spain to the borders of Persia, and from North Africa to Scotland.

EXPANSION

Rome began as a humble hill-top settlement in central Italy, but before long, it had conquered Italy. It then took over the northern Mediterranean before expanding into much of northern Europe, North Africa, and the Middle East.



1 240 BCE
After conquering Italy, Rome seized the island of Sicily, by defeating the city of Carthage in the First Punic War.



2 120 BCE
Forty years later, Rome took parts of Spain and North Africa in the Second Punic War. Victories against Macedonia gave it Greece.



3 14 CE
By the end of the reign of Emperor Augustus, Roman armies had advanced into Egypt, Syria, and much of Europe.

KEY
Roman Empire

ARMY

The Roman army was the ancient world's most effective fighting force. Professionally trained and armed, it had around 30 legions of 5,000 citizen-soldiers, each of whom served for 25 years.



BACKPACK
Roman soldiers carried cooking implements and tools to build a camp each night.

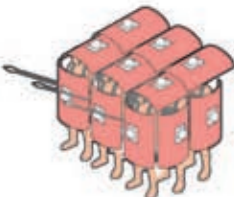


SHIELD
The legionary shield protected the whole body. Its edge could also be used to strike opponents.

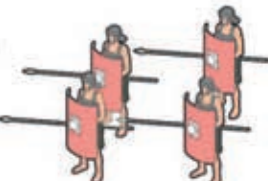


PUGIO
The Roman legionary dagger, or pugio, was around 20 cm (8 in) long. It was worn on the left hip.

GLADIUS
The Roman legionary sword, or gladius, was about 50 cm (20 in) long.



TESTUDO
Raised shields in the testudo, or "tortoise", defended against missiles dropped from above.



SKIRMISH
A skirmish formation was used for rapid advances or crossing difficult terrain.



ORB
The circular orb formation was used by small groups when surrounded.



CAVALRY DEFENCE
The front line held their javelins out at a 45-degree angle to defeat cavalry.

TACTICS AND FORMATIONS

The Romans were very effective foot (infantry) soldiers. Normally the legion would send a volley of arrows and javelins, before charging and fighting at close quarters. Very few enemies could defend themselves against them.



HELMET
Roman helmets had a metal bowl to protect the head, often with cheek pieces, and a horse-hair crest across the top.

ARMOUR
Body armour was usually formed of rectangular metal or leather strips.

KNEE GUARDS
Greaves protected their knees from sword blows.

SANDALS
Soldiers wore leather sandals with nails hammered into the soles.